Happenings in Handmade

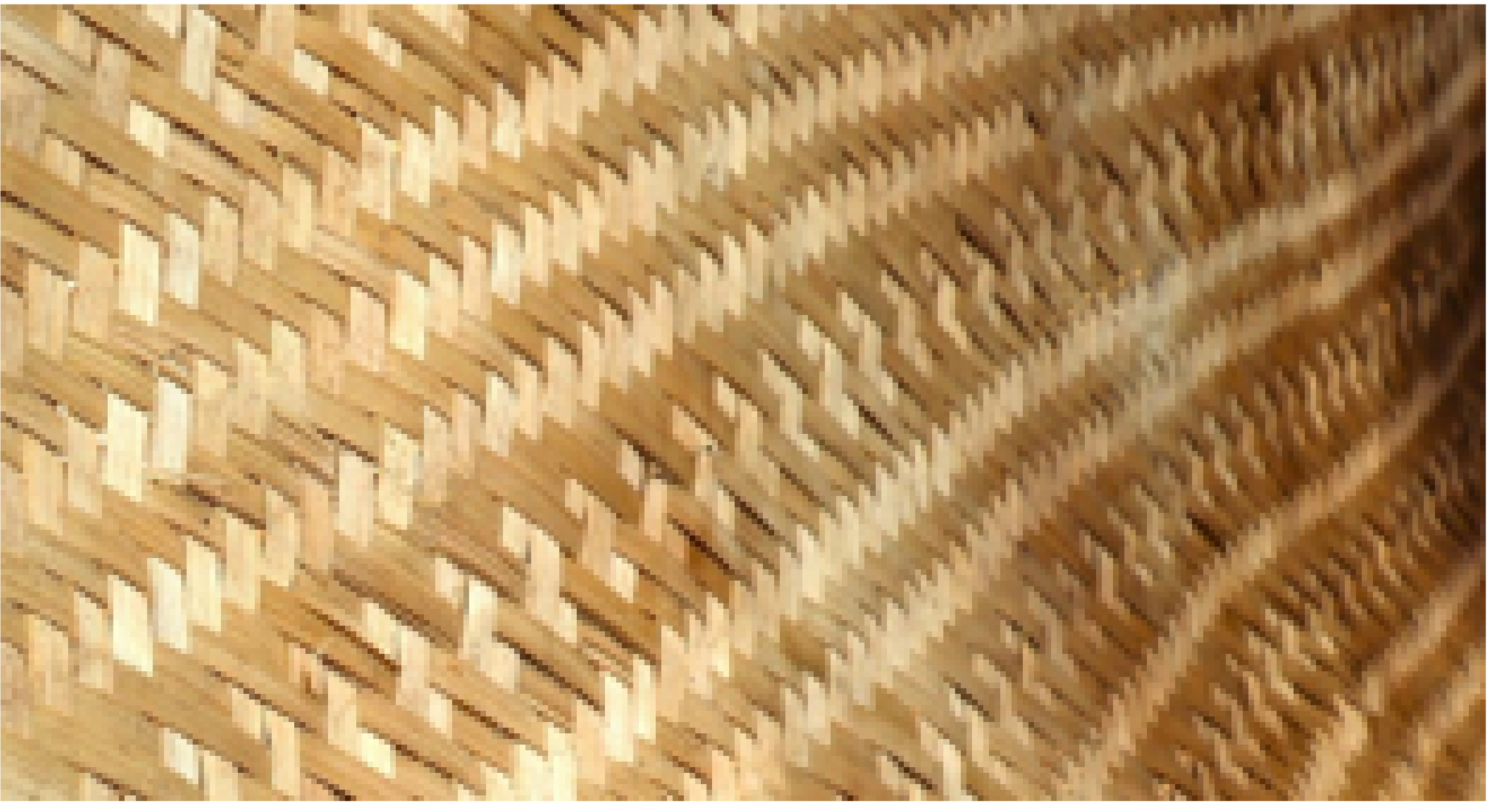
A CCI initiative

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SITTING ON STORIES

Exploring India's Rare Handwoven Mats

The humble woven mat has long been an integral part of rural life in India. From Satyajit Ray's villages to Kerala's art films, it appears beneath conversations, shared meals and afternoon naps, evoking memories of childhood summers and the quiet rhythms of village life.
Here, we look at a few of India's rare and remarkable handwoven mats.





Reed grass from swamps is dried and used to make mats

Wagguv mats are traditional Kashmiri floor mats made by weaving reed grass from ponds and waterways or from dried rice straw.

They are soft, eco-friendly, and keep homes warm in winter and cool in summer. The craft is about 300 years old.Traditionally, these mats were used in almost every mosque, shrine and Kashmiri home.



They were placed under carpets and bedding for insulation and comfort, making them an important part of daily life and local culture. Men collect the reeds, while women dry, weave, tighten, and trim the materials by hand to create durable mats ready for sale.





This languishing craft is being revived by the state government and now has a GI tag

Today, the craft is declining because of low demand and poor earnings. The Jammu and Kashmir Handicrafts Department has introduced registration, incentives, and support schemes to encourage artisans and help revive this traditional heritage.



Kauna phak or grass mat weaving, is a traditional craft of Manipur known for its use of soft, lightweight, and naturally durable kauna grass. The craft begins with sourcing kauna from local wetlands and cultivated fields, where the grass is harvested, cleaned, sorted, and sun-dried.

Artisans soften and prepare the dried stalks before weaving them by hand or on simple looms, carefully interlacing the grass to create strong and comfortable mats.

They are incredibly versatile and practical too, serving as mattresses in summer and light blankets during the monsoon season and winter.





Cultivated along with rice, Kauna grass is harvested by men and woven by women

Kannadippaya is a traditional handwoven "mirror mat" crafted by tribal communities of Kerala. It is woven from ultra-thin inner slivers of reed bamboo (*Teinostachyum wightii* and *Ochlandra travancorica*) found in the Western Ghats using a distinctive lattice technique.



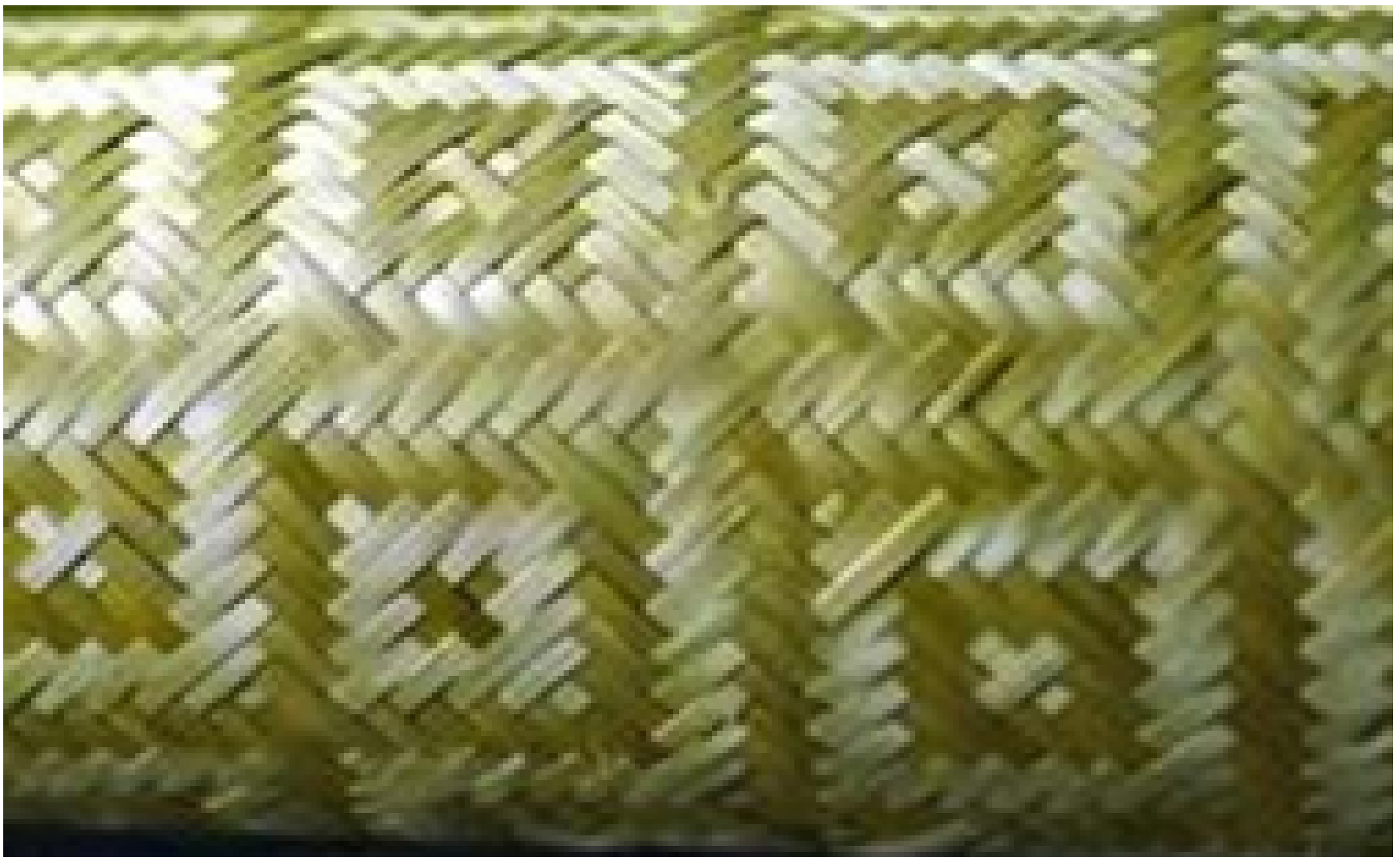
Preparing the slivers and handweaving process



Traditionally, production was organised at the household level. Men generally undertook the physically demanding work of harvesting bamboo from the forest and preparing the raw material by splitting the culms. Women were the principal weavers, making the lattice patterns that create the mirror effect. Children and elders often assisted by sorting, cleaning and preparing strips.Kannadippaya weaving is a collaborative family activity and an important means of passing knowledge between generations.



Today, revival initiatives have trained large numbers of women artisans through tribal cooperatives, helping sustain both livelihoods and traditional knowledge. Traditionally used as sleeping and sitting mats, Kannadippaya is now being revived through its 2025 GI tag and is finding new markets as a sustainable, eco-friendly heritage craft and premium home décor product.



Resting beneath our feet yet rising far beyond the ordinary, the **Waguuv**, **Kannadippaya**, and **Kauna phak** embody India's rich craft heritage, where skilled hands, timeless techniques, and humble materials weave stories of culture, community, and enduring beauty.

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